Social Connectedness and Mental Health - The Mediating Roles of Social Isolation and Loneliness

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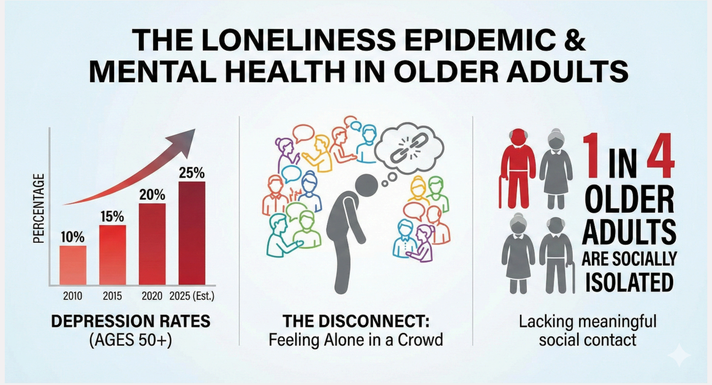
Introduction



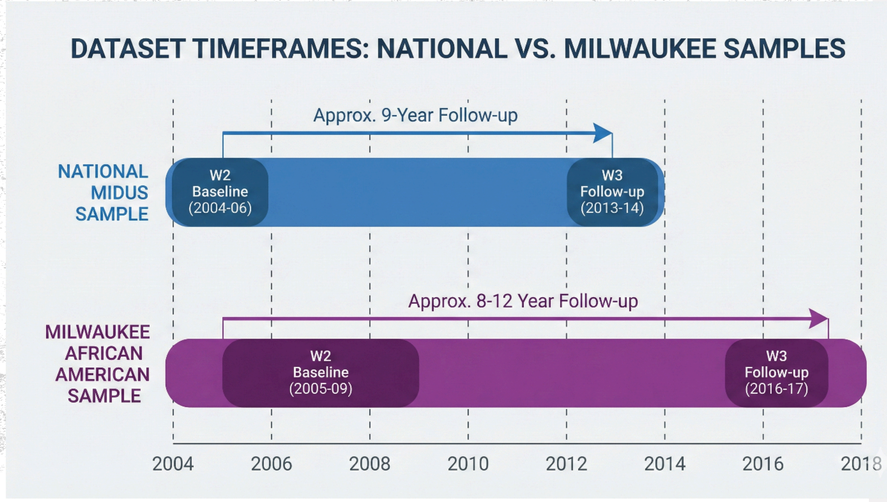
The"BlackBox"of Social Connectedness

- Social connectedness is a critical resource for healthy aging, but its mechanisms are often conflated.
- Two pathways:
  - Subjective **loneliness**
  - Objective: **social isolation**
- Population differences?

Population

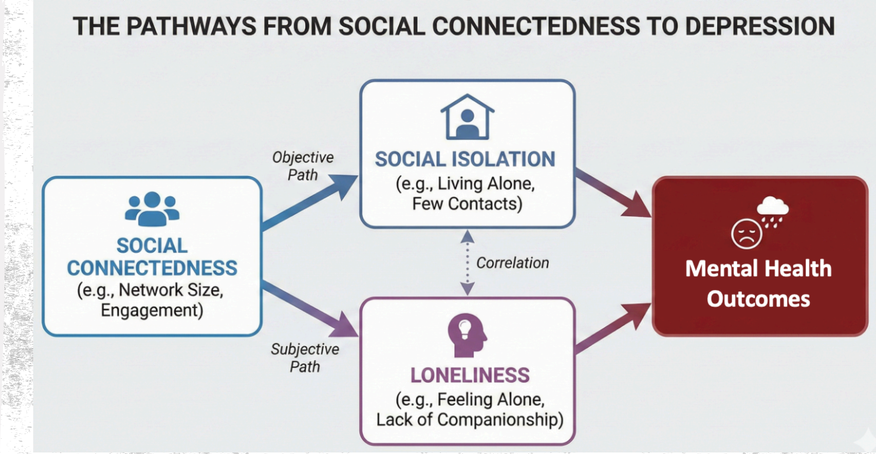
Midlife in the United States (MIDUS) study.

- Nationally sample (N=4,963); Black Americans from Milwaukee, WI (N=592)



Analytic Strategies

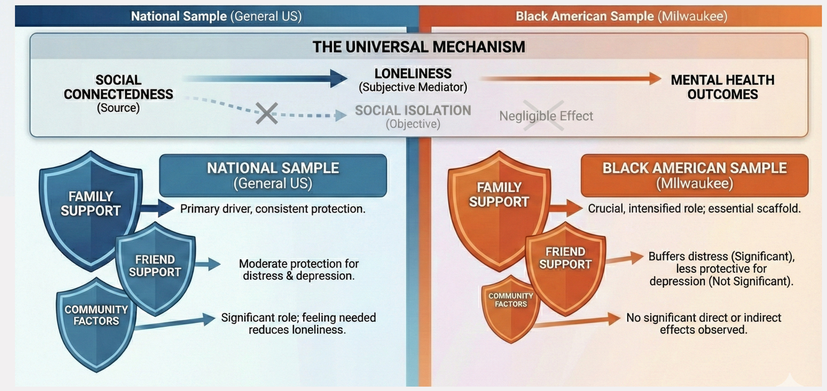
- Longitudinal analysis
- Structural equation models: direct and indirect pathways
- Inverse Probability Weighting: selection bias and confounding.



Measures

Predictor: Social Connectedness	Mediators	Mental Health Outcomes	Covariates
• Social integration • Social contribution • Community contribution • Neighborhood social cohesion • Support from family • Support from friends	• Social isolation (composite score of frequency of social contact) • Loneliness (subjective of loneliness feeling)	Depressive symptoms (Depressed affect symptoms) Psychological distress (Kessler-6 scale)	**Demographics:** Age, sex, education, marital status. **Health:** Self-rated physical health, functional status. **Contextual:** Homeownership, years in neighborhood, employment status. **Culture-Specific:** Spirituality for the Black American sample.

Key Findings



Takeaway

Different protective mechanisms operate across populations

- Target subjective loneliness
- Screen for "connected" but lonely patients
- Family system support is crucial
- Differential social resources

Limitations

- Loneliness and social isolation measures
- Longitudinal attrition
- Limited generalization for the Black adults sample

Acknowledgments

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